Contrary to the claims of many scholars and analysts, its main driving forces are subtle, long-term, and less glamorous than the so-called containment of China (though it is certainly driven by the threat of a rising China). Based on the framework offered in the introduction to this volume, this chapter discusses if India's growing alignment with Japan is an effort of balancing against China or if it should rather be understood as part of a more mixed strategy of cooperation and confrontation toward China.[9]

In the next section, I investigate some common explanations for why the India–Japan relationship has deepened since 2000 and show why they are insufficient for explaining the unusually high level of strategic partnership between India and Japan. I then propose an alternative explanation, in the form of an implicit bargain between the two countries, according to which Japan invests in bolstering India's long-term capabilities and in policy coordination with India while India offers diplomatic support and weight to Japan's increasingly precarious position in East Asia. In the concluding section, I examine the factors that will shape the trajectory of the India–Japan relationship going forward.

Common but inadequate explanations for India's Japan policy

The objective calculus of a deepening India–Japan relationship since the turn of the 21st century seems fairly straightforward. Since the end of the Cold War, India has sought to diversify its strategic partnerships and build relationships with countries that were formerly out of bounds due to US–Soviet competition and Delhi's non-aligned foreign policy. Thus a deeper relationship with Japan – the world's fourth-largest economy (in PPP terms) with a